been divided into segments for the purpose of search, which began at about 7 a.m. We had no hard intelligence inputs on the hideouts or locations of the terrorists, so we didn't expect anything much to come out of this operation. But we were in for a surprise. As soon as the searches commenced, I moved my tactical HQ to the hill in the centre of Anantnag town. From there we had a 360-degree view of the town. Within an hour, an exchange of fire took place between one of our search parties and terrorists hiding in the attic of a house. I learnt that in the shootout our soldiers had killed one terrorist and caught one alive. Both were armed with AK-47s.

I asked the company commander concerned to bring that terrorist to my location immediately so that we could find out all that he knew, and take follow-up actions. Based on my experience and whatever I had learnt in the Intelligence School, I am convinced that information can be extracted only in the initial stages, when the subject is under shock, unstable and afraid. In this case, he broke down very easily and told us of a huge cache of weapons and ammunition in a shop in the nearby market. I ordered the company commander to proceed with the terrorist and unearth the cache. However, the terrorist lost his nerve on reaching the area, claiming he couldn't identify the exact place. We combed the area by searching each shop systematically and eventually our perseverance paid. We hit a veritable gold mine – a large cache of arms and ammunition in the heart of the town, the first such seizure in Anantnag. These included a sizeable number of rifles, machine guns, rocket launchers, large quantities of ammunition, grenades, rockets and other items.

A realistic but sad dimension of this conflict came to my notice when I was listening into the radio communications on the 17 J&K Rifles net. The conversation on the radio network centred around a baby found abandoned in our area of operations. The unwanted child, probably fathered by a militant, was handed over to an orphanage. Unfortunately, a number of such cases have been reported during this so-called jehad.

The corps commander and the GOC of the division, Generals Zaki and Malik, drove down to congratulate me and my units. Their visit